Name: Jack Flax Date:

002C.1 — Thursday October 15 — The Northern Renaissance

DO NOW — How did reusable type help ideas spread?

through the Printing press

The Northern Renaissance

CLASSWORK — [2:23–2:45] After finishing 002B, read selected passages together: Introduction/Gutenberg; Faust; deus secundus and limited partnership; Erasmus; the mysticism definition and ritual qualification. Record one short phrase each for printing, Faust and deus secundus. Discuss Questions 1–3 orally, compare Van Eyck with Raphael, and write one continuity/change sentence. Finish the remaining prose for Monday.

INTRODUCTION

> Following the beginning of the Italian Renaissance, there was a Renaissance in northern Europe too, which is sometimes called the Northern Renaissance.
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> The Northern Renaissance was more overtly religious than the Italian Renaissance, focusing more on the revival of Christianity, albeit from a more humanistic perspective. Both renaissances included a great deal of art, and religious art in particular.
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> But the Italian Renaissance placed more of an emphasis on aesthetics, while the Northern Renaissance was more mystical in its view of God and religion. There was overlap between them, but these were the general tendencies.

READING — Print, knowledge, human agency, and religious humanism

One of the accomplishments of the Northern Renaissance was the establishment of new universities to raise the level of scholarship and higher learning in Europe. The most famous new university (as opposed to the old great universities, like the University of Paris, Oxford, and Cambridge) was in the German city of Wittenberg. This will be important when we discuss the Protestant Reformation, because that's where Martin Luther was a professor. It also features in Shakespeare's Hamlet, as the location where the main character - Hamlet - studied.

Around 1450, Johannes Gutenberg developed a practical European printing system combining movable metal type, suitable ink, and a press. Producing many copies from reusable type helped lower the cost of texts and widen their circulation; access and literacy nevertheless remained unequal.

Woodblock printing and movable type had earlier histories in East Asia, and woodblock printing also existed in Europe. Gutenberg's achievement belongs within that longer printing history, while his European system had far-reaching consequences.

The Bible was the most in-demand book in Europe for obvious reasons, and one of the first products of the new printing press was what became known as the "Gutenberg Bible" (1455).

The greater availability of information would help spur on the development of culture in the Northern Renaissance.

All sorts of texts that emphasized the power of the human being would be spread around Europe by the printing press. The story of Dr. Faustus (often simply called "Faust") became particularly famous. He was a man who was rumored to have sold his soul to the devil so that he could become knowledgeable and powerful. Christopher Marlowe dramatized the story in England by 1593, as Palmer & Colton note on p. 63. (It continued to be cherished for centuries – it was used by Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, one of the greatest German writers, across the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.)

This story addressed a profound question: What is the relationship between knowledge and goodness?

We all know of people who are pious simpletons – people who have good hearts and a strong sense of right and wrong, even though they don't have strong educations.

And then there's the opposite: it's possible to be educated but still be a horrible person. People commonly note that some of the Nazis and Communists were well-educated.

Why, then, should we be educated? Well, partly because education isn't simply about morality – it helps us to live better as human beings in other ways. But we also hope that a serious engagement with knowledge will teach us choices and consequences, in order to improve our character.

There's even a word "Faustian" which means someone who is short-sighted in pursuit of knowledge or power. We can sell our souls to the devil in the pursuit of something that seems good, but lose sight of what we should be in the process. Again, this is a cautionary tale directed towards an era in which human beings seemed capable of doing so much, even becoming the masters of the contours of their own horizons.

Northern Renaissance thought reflected this outlook when it came to its religious thinking. Nicholas of Cusa (1401-1464) was an important intellectual from Central Europe (he lived in several different places) in the blurry space between the Middle Ages and the Northern Renaissance.

Cusa argued on philosophical and theological grounds that the universe has no exact physical center and that apparent centrality depends on the observer. God, for Cusa, is its true center and circumference. This was a challenge to a fixed cosmological picture, not an experimentally established version of modern cosmology.

Cusa's argument predates Copernicus, but the two should not be conflated: Cusa reasons from his metaphysics, while Copernicus develops a mathematical account of planetary motions centered on the Sun.

Consider the debate between the great early twentieth-century yeshivas, Nevardok and Slabodka. Nevardok emphasized shiflus ha-adam – the lowness of man. Slabodka emphasized gadlus ha-adam – the greatness of man. The Renaissance was emphasizing the latter approach, while the Middle Ages tended to emphasize the former (The exception was medieval mysticism, which emphasized the importance of man).

Nicholas of Cusa also thought of man as "deus secundus" – literally a "second god." Now, it's important to explain what he meant.

He did not mean that man is a god.

A Jewish comparison can illuminate this idea: we are God's partner. These parallels are our classroom comparison, not quotations from Cusa or proof that these particular sources influenced him. We are not like God in the way that the Greeks thought we are like little gods. God does not want us to be quite like Him – that's why the Torah says we were kicked out of the Garden of Eden, lest we become like God by eating from both the Tree of Knowledge and Tree of Life. God wants a partner who is limited and who feels an imperative to create and improve. (A "junior partner.") Many Jewish sources would emphasize this notion of partnership with God, including Rabbi Joseph Soloveitchik. Nicholas of Cusa offered a serious philosophical approach to this concept, one which encouraged people to be creative in the Renaissance.

Now, Nicholas's idea raised a real problem. If we are supposed to be so active in taking ownership of our lives, then we can ask the question: "Why do I need God at all? Why can't I create without Him?"

Confidence in human agency can raise the question of whether people still acknowledge God as the source of their freedom. This is a theological question for discussion, not evidence that Renaissance humanism inevitably produced atheism or moral evil. Cusa's deus secundus preserves human dependence on God rather than endorsing self-deification.

Nicholas' philosophical outlook may have helped spark the Scientific Revolution. In his dialogue On Experiments with Weight-Scales (1450), he proposed quantitative investigations, including ways to compare the weights of air and water. A proposed experiment is not evidence that he successfully performed it.

Man is a second God	
Bad way to understand: self-deification	**Good way to understand**
Man is kicked out of Eden for wanting to be like God At the Tower of Babel, man wanted to take over God's role and it ended terribly The ruler of Tyre claims to be a god (Yechezkel 28:2); compare Pharaoh's claim about the Nile (29:3).	God acts through man Man is a partner with God – build, create, civilize the world as a party to the covenant

Biblical comparisons: Ezekiel 28:2 (ruler of Tyre), https://mechon-mamre.org/p/pt/pt1228.htm ; 29:3 (Pharaoh), https://mechon-mamre.org/p/pt/pt1229.htm

And when it came to a religious outlook that promoted the importance of the individual, that role was played by Mysticism, which continued to spread after the Middle Ages – mysticism was the belief that the individual can commune with God outside of social settings.

Meister Eckhart was an interesting 14th century medieval mystic, following Thomas Aquinas, who, despite his great reputation as a rationalist, also had a mystical side in the 13th century. Nicholas of Cusa was a mystic in the 15th century, as were many lay people who gained the acceptance of the official church.

Mysticism also spread in Jewish communities, too, branching out from medieval Kabbalah, including the study of the Zohar and works like the Iggeret HaKodesh, all the way to the Kabbalah of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the Arizal) in the 16th century.

Mysticism emphasized the ability of the individual to connect with God. The potential problem it created for religion was that it opened the door to the possibility that traditional religious belief and practice didn't really matter - it's possible that only the religious experience matters, but not going to a house of worship, engaging in a ritual act, etc. But mysticism can simply maintain that religious acts have incalculable significance. This can be seen in a variety of mystical works that backed up the significance of ritual religious observance for the individual's approach to God, for example, in Nefesh HaChaim in the 18th/19th centuries.

ARTISTS:

Jan Van Eyck

Bosch

Bruegel

THINKERS:

Erasmus exemplifies Christian humanism: study of classical languages and early Christian sources was directed toward better education, moral reform, and reform of the Church. He criticized abuses while resisting the religious rupture associated with Luther.

Thomas More (English Renaissance)

Rabelais

John Parkin's account, quoted in the linked "Gargantua and Pantagruel" article, identifies four humorous agendas:

the "campaigns in which Rabelais engaged, using laughter to enhance his principles";

he "derides medieval scholarship both in its methods and its representatives";

he "mocks ritual prayer, the traffic in indulgences, monasticism, pilgrimage, Roman rather than universal Catholicism, and its converse, dogmatic Protestantism";

and he "lampoons the emperor Charles V, implying that his policies are tyrannical".

Rabelais commentary: John Parkin, in Elizabeth Chesney Zegura, ed., The Rabelais Encyclopedia (2004), p. 122, quoted via https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gargantua_and_Pantagruel#Satire ; historical reference: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Charles_V,_Holy_Roman_Emperor

CUE / CONCEPT	ONE PHRASE — printing, Faust, deus secundus
Universities / Wittenberg What changed in higher learning? Why does Wittenberg matter?	• teaches in Wit Fictional Martin Luther & Hamlet go to colleg • center for north Ger. scholarship in the university.
Gutenberg / printing press Technology, date, and effects on books and ideas	• 1450 • cheaper, faster, more efficient way • to spread ideas. more literacy Faster circulation.

CUE / CONCEPT	ONE PHRASE — printing, Faust, deus secundus
Faust Story + central problem about knowledge and goodness	• giving up words for knowledge •
Nicholas of Cusa Perspective, God, and human significance	• • •
deus secundus What does "second god" mean—and what does it NOT mean?	• • •
Mysticism Definition, examples, and possible tension	• • •
Artists / humanists Van Eyck, Bosch, Bruegel; Erasmus, More, Rabelais	• •
Northern vs. Italian Renaissance One continuity + one difference	• • •

KEY TERMS

Johannes Gutenberg, Gutenberg Bible, printing press, movable type

Nicholas of Cusa, deus secundus

Dr. Faust

Mysticism

Erasmus, Christian humanism

SUMMARY

The Northern Renaissance thought about God in more mystical terms, rather than primarily aesthetic terms.

Gutenberg's printing press and movable type drastically changed how quickly ideas could spread.

Nicholas of Cusa described human beings as a "second God," emphasizing limited human creativity under God rather than self-deification. Our Jewish comparison connects this responsibility to creating and civilizing the world as a party to the covenant.

The story of Dr. Faust shows that knowledge and goodness do not necessarily go together, but we hope that education can teach us choices and help us refine our character.

Mysticism became a significant movement. Mysticism is the belief that man can commune with God outside of social settings. Mysticism also emphasized that man's actions fundamentally matter.

MET NORTHERN COMPARISON — Use the Metropolitan Museum of Art image printed below: Jan van Eyck, The Crucifixion; The Last Judgment. Name one detail that creates depth and one sacred subject that remains. Compare orally with Wednesday's Raphael altarpiece.



Jan van Eyck and workshop assistant, The Crucifixion; The Last Judgment, ca. 1436–38. Oil on canvas transferred from wood. The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/436282

Discuss orally — Palmer & Colton Questions 1–3, pp. 62–67

Palmer & Colton's central distinction is careful: north of the Alps there was a Renaissance, but people were generally less conscious of a sudden break with the Middle Ages. The northern movement blended older religious concerns with new humanist scholarship.

1. What makes northern humanism "Christian humanism" in Palmer & Colton's account? Name the kinds of texts its scholars studied and the purpose of that study.

2. What role did printing and the growth of vernacular languages play in spreading Renaissance learning north of Italy?

3. Erasmus wanted reform without religious revolution. Identify two methods or virtues Palmer & Colton associate with his approach and explain how each fits that goal.

WRITING PRACTICE — Write a one-sentence summary of the Northern Renaissance that includes both continuity and change. Your sentence must use "although" or "while."

HOMEWORK — Monday, October 19

Finish 002C.1 through SUMMARY. Read P&C pp. 67–74, beginning at "8. The New Monarchies." Answer the three questions below in 1–2 sentences each, using a detail from the reading. Allow about 30–40 minutes across the weekend for both readings and answers.

1. Why does Cusa's idea of the human being as a "second god" encourage inquiry without making human beings God's equals? Use one example from 002C.1.

Cusa's idea of man as a second God
would keep people ask questions but it also
stresses the human creativity is limited
under God

2. Why would townspeople support a king who weakened their parliament? Explain the trade-off using P&C p. 67.

They wanted stability instead of a
parliament.

3. Why did the Habsburgs' success in acquiring territory fail to turn the Holy Roman Empire into a unified state? Use one detail from P&C pp. 71–74.

Since the Habsburgs expanded power
through marriage. They never really worked
together, they just agreed not to fight. leaving
the m
with a
political
piece missing

Bring 002C.1 and 002C.2 Monday. Items 1–15 in 002C.2 remain classwork. Quiz Thursday, October 22; study 002SG1.

NEXT HANDOUT — Monday October 19: 002C.2 —
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Blj8bAkRTAZcZ-1i-yJelwMX_dySVyoZ/edit

Sources: Palmer & Colton, A History of the Modern World, 8th ed., pp. 62–74.